

A Decision-Focused Proposal-Comparison Brief for Pittsburgh Housing

Findings and product implications

Core finding: the useful product is not a zoning score, a feasibility score, or a declaration that Proposal B is “better.” It is a **source-dated decision-delta brief** that tells a practitioner, in one view: what the applicant is trying to preserve; what physically changed between two proposal versions; which regulatory checks changed because of those changes; which constraints did not move; what housing and non-housing outcomes changed; what is merely a developer, community, or consultant claim; what is still unknown; and the single next document or professional judgment needed before making the next decision.

Shur Save supports that conclusion, but not because it proves there was an obvious better design that software would have found. The public record shows a complicated mixed-use proposal with 248 apartments, a grocery store, additional retail, a plaza, inclusionary units, parking, neighborhood commitments, multiple zoning-relief requests, and later financial/site-condition arguments. It also shows an earlier 2021 Echo concept with 190 apartments and four stories. What the record **does not** establish is that those were two simultaneously viable choices, or that a fully documented by-right alternative existed when the Zoning Board ruled. ¹

That distinction matters for the product. At Shur Save, a comparison tool could have been valuable primarily as a **version-control and tradeoff-organizing instrument**: “the unit count increased; the maximum building height increased; this relief is now implicated; these community objectives remain; these commitments have changed status; financial feasibility has not been independently demonstrated.” It would probably not have taught the applicant's architect or zoning counsel that a six-story project in the LNC district required relief. The LNC code capped height at 45 feet and three stories, while separate Residential Compatibility Standards imposed height/setback rules near residential zoning; those are precisely the kinds of checks professionals would already identify. ²

The stronger prototype case is **Lanark Street in Fineview**. The documented original program was eight affordable new homes—six attached and two detached. After neighbors successfully challenged the zoning approval, the development organizations announced that they would still build eight homes but make all eight detached. That gives a much cleaner comparison: the housing count and stated affordability objective stay fixed while the physical form changes, one identified zoning problem changes, and cost/time consequences are asserted but not independently established. ³

The product implications are therefore:

Product implication	Why the evidence points there
Compare proposal versions, not just parcels.	At Shur Save, 2021 and 2023 concepts differed materially; at Lanark, attached versus all-detached versions changed the regulatory picture while preserving eight homes. ⁴
Give every option a status: active, superseded, announced revision, or hypothetical.	Echo's 2021 concept is documented, but there is no evidence that it remained a live alternative in 2023. BDC discussed the possibility of a by-right alternative after denial, but did not document one. ⁵
Show the regulatory delta and the outcome delta separately.	Fewer approval steps are not themselves a housing outcome. Lanark's announced revision retained eight homes; Shur Save combined substantial housing with grocery, retail, and community commitments despite needing relief. ⁶
Version community commitments just like design dimensions.	In July 2023 Echo publicly said it would encourage a future housing operator to accept vouchers; by the November decision, WESA and BDC reported a commitment to accept Housing Choice Vouchers. A brief that simply said "vouchers: yes" would erase a consequential change in certainty. ⁷
Never convert a financial claim into a feasibility conclusion.	Echo said additional height was needed to cover project costs, including below-market units; its later appeal argued that topography and soil conditions created expensive constraints. No public pro forma, construction budget, lender underwriting, or independently tested residual-land-value analysis was recovered in this research. ⁸
Make "unknown" an output, not an error.	The full Shur Save ZBA decision/application PDFs could not be retrieved here, the four reported variance requests could not all be identified from accessible sources, and the detailed 2021 concept was not found. Those gaps are decision-relevant facts in their own right. ⁹
End with a role + document + reason, not a generic recommendation.	Pittsburgh's zoning process turns on project-specific application materials and approval criteria; the useful next step is often to obtain or revise a site plan, zoning determination, application, technical study, or financing input before drawing the next conclusion.

The private SME comments supplied with this request are treated here only as **initial concept feedback**. They are not treated as evidence of product demand, market uniqueness, or permission to attribute or publish a private message.

Shur Save decision record

Method and historical-rule caveat. I followed the public reporting toward City and court records where possible. Several original Pittsburgh PDFs—the Shur Save ZBA decision, ZBA agenda/application material, and the community-guidelines PDF—timed out or were blocked when fetched. Because those PDFs could

not be rendered, I did not derive page-specific facts from them. For historical zoning, the strongest available cross-check is that the current eCode pages themselves identify the LNC provisions as originating in Ordinance 45-2003 and the relevant Residential Compatibility chapter as effective in 2018, both before the 2023 decision; contemporary 2023 reporting independently says this site was limited to three stories. This is strong evidence of the applicable framework, but it is **not a substitute for an archived November 2023 code snapshot.** ¹⁰

Raw facts, separated from interpretation

Item	Fact established in the reviewed record
Parcel/project	4401 Liberty Avenue, former ShurSave/current-at-the-time Community Market site in Bloomfield. Reporting described the overall property as roughly two acres; Echo's later appeal referred to the relevant site as 1.7 acres. The discrepancy should be retained rather than silently normalized. ¹¹
Applicant/developer	Echo Realty, proceeding as Bloomfield Bridge Associates LLC in the zoning appeal. ¹²
2023 housing	248 rental apartments. July reporting gave 56 studios, 127 one-bedrooms and 65 two-bedrooms; 25 were identified as inclusionary/affordable units. ¹³
Affordability rule	Bloomfield entered the City's Inclusionary Housing Overlay effective May 2, 2022. For covered projects, the ordinance requires at least 10% inclusionary units; rental eligibility/pricing is tied to 50% AMI, with a 35-year minimum affordability term. ¹⁴
Non-housing program	A new grocery store, about 10,000 square feet of additional retail, and an outdoor/public plaza were reported. ⁹
Height/form	The 2023 design reached six stories; PublicSource described five stories of apartments over the grocery portion and four stories over retail portions. Exact proposed height in feet was not recovered. ¹⁵
Parking	PublicSource reported 199 underground spaces plus 119 spaces on the first floor/mezzanine, with parking placed behind, beneath, or within the buildings rather than in a large surface field. ¹⁵
LNC base rule	§904.02 lists a 45-foot maximum, not to exceed three stories, and makes the Residential Compatibility Standards applicable where triggered. The section records an effective date in 2003, predating the 2023 case. ¹⁶
Residential Compatibility	Chapter 916, effective in its relevant form from 2018, applies additional constraints near residential zoning; its building-height standards limit structures within 50 feet of specified residential districts to 40 feet/three stories and structures 51–100 feet away to 50 feet/four stories. Its waiver provision sharply limits when compatibility-related height may be waived. ¹⁷

Item	Fact established in the reviewed record
Requested relief	Contemporary reporting said Echo sought four variances . A height variance was one. The later decision reporting specifically identifies denial of the height request and a request involving Residential Compatibility Standards. The exact sections and disposition of all four variance requests could not be recovered from the accessible record. ⁹
Grocery approval	WESA reported that the ZBA approved the special exception associated with the grocery use, finding sufficient evidence that the location was appropriate and applicable criteria could be met. ¹⁸
Community commitments	By the November decision, Echo was reported to have committed to Housing Choice Voucher acceptance and pedestrian improvements. BDC also described commitments concerning supplemental grocery access during construction and pedestrian/traffic safety. ¹⁹
Financial claims	Echo officials said six stories were needed to cover project costs, including costs associated with renting 10% of units below market. In its later court appeal, Echo's counsel said the 1.7-acre site's topography and soil conditions created uniquely difficult and expensive development constraints. These are developer/appellant claims , not an independent feasibility finding. ⁸
Independent feasibility evidence	Not found. No public pro forma, lender underwriting, hard/soft-cost schedule, rent roll, grocery lease economics, return threshold, or comparable financial model was recovered.
Earlier same-developer concept	PublicSource reports Echo's original 2021 concept as a four-story complex with 190 apartments. Sufficient public detail on its retail, parking, unit mix, affordability, geometry, approvals or financial assumptions was not found . ¹⁵
Earlier different-developer concept	Milhaus proposed 237 apartments in 2018 without retaining a grocery store; it met intense opposition and the developer later walked away. ²⁰

Dated chronology and what was knowable when

Date	Record	Decision-time status
January 2018	BDC says almost 400 people attended a meeting on the then-proposed redevelopment. The Milhaus concept subsequently documented in reporting contained 237 apartments and no grocery store. ²¹	Background available before Echo.
Late 2018	Milhaus dropped its bid after significant community opposition. ¹⁵	Background.

Date	Record	Decision-time status
Early 2019	BDC, ACTION-Housing and Studio for Spatial Practice ran workshops to create the Bloomfield Central Gateway Development Guidelines. Later BDC accounts identify housing and a grocery store as the two most desired uses; PublicSource records avoiding surface parking among the recommendations. ²²	Community objectives available to later developers.
Early 2020	Echo bought the property; BDC subsequently collected more than 700 petition signatures supporting community-oriented redevelopment. Community Market continued grocery service. ²³	Known before design development.
2021	Echo's first publicly documented concept: four stories and 190 apartments. Detailed program/application material was not recovered. ¹⁵	The closest same-developer documented comparison point , but not shown to be a live 2023 alternative.
May 2, 2022	Ordinance 12 became effective, expanding the Inclusionary Housing Overlay into Bloomfield and other neighborhoods. ²⁴	Binding regulatory input before the 2023 application.
July 11–15, 2023	Echo/Bloomfield Development Corporation presented the 248-unit mixed-use project at community meetings. Four variances were reported, including the six-versus-three-story issue. Public reporting also documented 10,000 square feet of other retail, the plaza, parking, streetscape/transit concerns, and affordability. ²⁵	Good pre-ZBA comparison moment. Most physical-program and zoning inputs existed.
July 2023	On vouchers, Echo's vice president was reported as saying he would encourage the eventual housing operator to accept them; an operator had not yet been identified. ²⁵	Commitment was not yet as firm as later accounts describe—an important versioned input.
August 10, 2023	Scheduled ZBA hearing on the requested relief. ¹⁵	Formal adjudicative decision point.
November 6, 2023	ZBA decision issued. Requested variances were rejected; reporting specifically identifies height and Residential Compatibility problems. The grocery special exception was approved. The Board's rationale included that changing the LNC height rule was a legislative/policy question and that it was not persuaded the requested variances were the minimum relief necessary. ²⁶	Primary decision point.

Date	Record	Decision-time status
November 6–7, 2023	By this point WESA and BDC reported firmer community commitments: voucher acceptance, pedestrian/safety measures, and supplemental grocery access during construction. BDC worried a by-right alternative could lose negotiated commitments, but did not publish an actual by-right design. ²⁷	Known consequence/uncertainty immediately after denial.
December 2023	Echo appealed. The appeal asserted that difficult topography and soil conditions created expensive site-specific constraints and argued the Board should have granted dimensional relief. ¹²	Later development. The appeal says such evidence had been presented below, but the accessible public source documenting the argument is later, so it should not be silently backdated.
January 30, 2024	BDC announced that it had moved to intervene in the appeal, emphasizing grocery access and affordable housing. ²⁸	Later development.
July 11, 2024	BDC announced that Giant Eagle would acquire 4401 Liberty and continue grocery operations; the Echo housing development, including the affordable units, would not proceed at that time. ²⁹	Later outcome—not evidence the November 2023 Board knew housing would be lost.

That final distinction is important. A comparison brief should never say, retrospectively, “denying the variance caused the project to lose 248 homes” as though that outcome was determined on November 6, 2023. The public record supports a sequence—denial, appeal, intervention, later transfer and loss of the housing proposal—not a single verified causal claim that the denial alone necessarily produced the July 2024 result. ³⁰

What objectives were actually in play? Housing objectives included adding 248 rental homes and the inclusionary units, while community advocates also pursued voucher access. Non-housing objectives included preserving full-service grocery access, adding other retail, providing an outdoor plaza, improving pedestrian/traffic conditions, preserving transit/pedestrian connections, avoiding a return to a surface-parking-dominated site, and maintaining grocery access during construction. The 2019 community process is especially important because it demonstrates that “housing yield” and “number of approvals” were not the only objectives a legitimate comparison needed to carry forward. ³¹

Which Shur Save comparison could actually have helped? The defensible documented pair is **Echo 2021: four stories/190 apartments** versus **Echo 2023: up to six stories/248 apartments plus the documented 2023 mixed-use program**. But the tool should stamp Proposal A “**superseded historical concept; completeness low**”, not present it as a ready-to-build alternative. Only its height and unit count were recovered. A practitioner could use the comparison in July/August 2023 to ask which additional zoning checks and public commitments accompanied the changed program and which design assumptions needed documentation before proceeding. ¹⁵

A comparison between the **2023 proposal and “a by-right alternative” cannot honestly be populated from the reviewed evidence.** Immediately after the ZBA decision, BDC itself wondered what such a development would look like; that is evidence that an alternative was a question, not a documented scheme. ¹⁹

To turn that hypothetical into a genuine Proposal B, at minimum the practitioner would need a dated alternative site plan; parcel/lot boundaries and surveyed grades; building footprint, height and story count; distance to residentially zoned property for Chapter 916 checks; grocery/retail floor area; residential unit and bedroom counts; parking/loading/access; inclusionary-unit treatment; open-space/pedestrian scheme; and a zoning-review determination identifying by-right uses and any remaining administrative, special-exception, variance or Planning Commission review. Financial viability would still have to remain “**not evaluated**” until credible cost, revenue, financing, lease and site-condition inputs were supplied. The importance of distances to residential property and the base three-story LNC limit follows directly from Chapters 904 and 916. ³²

What was probably already obvious to the professionals? The three-story LNC limit, the fact that six stories implicated substantial height relief, the existence of Residential Compatibility checks, the Inclusionary Housing requirement, and the need to go through the ZBA were not hidden insights that comparison software needed to “discover.” Contemporary public coverage was already discussing all of them before the hearing. ⁹

What could software add? The realistic incremental value is **traceability across versions**: “190 → 248 units; four → six stories; affordability overlay now applies; voucher statement changes from encouragement → reported commitment; grocery remains an objective; height issue remains unresolved; financial necessity remains a party claim; exact four-variance checklist is incomplete.” That is not novel zoning analysis. It is a compact, auditable way to keep a multidisciplinary decision from being distorted by incomplete memory, stale plans, or a single dimension such as approval count. The changing voucher language is a particularly good example of information that exists publicly but is easy to flatten incorrectly. ⁷

Smaller transferable case and demo recommendation

The strongest small-infill case found in the Pro-Housing Pittsburgh starting material is **Lanark Street in Fineview**, associated with City of Bridges Community Land Trust and Fineview Citizens Council. Pro-Housing's article uses 21 Lanark Street—an existing attached rowhouse on land it identifies as R1D-H—to illustrate the neighborhood's mismatch between historic attached form and current detached zoning. Because Pro-Housing is an advocacy organization, I do **not** treat its calculated setbacks/by-right envelope as independently verified here; its underlying parcel and code claims should be checked against the official ZBA file before being encoded as rules. ³³

The consequential development facts are independently reported by WESA. The organizations sought to construct eight new affordable single-family homes for households below 80% AMI: **two groups of three attached homes plus two detached homes.** In March 2023 the ZBA granted two variances and a special exception, reported as relief involving attached dwellings and parking. Two neighbors challenged the decision. ³⁴

In September 2023, Common Pleas Judge Mary McGinley ruled that the project should not have received the zoning variance. City of Bridges and Fineview Citizens Council then announced a revised approach: still **eight new homes, but all detached**. City of Bridges Executive Director Ed Nusser estimated that the required change would add roughly \$120,000 and at least a year for fundraising, engineering and additional zoning review. Those figures should appear in a comparison as **“developer estimate/claim,” not a verified cost model.** ³⁵

That creates a much cleaner decision pattern than Shur Save:

Dimension	Shur Save	Lanark
Basic comparison	2021 four-story/190-unit historical concept versus 2023 six-story/248-unit proposal; older option poorly documented. ¹⁵	Original six-attached/two-detached eight-home proposal versus announced eight-detached-home revision. ³
Housing objective	High unit count plus inclusionary affordability; voucher commitment added through community process. ¹⁹	Eight affordable homes below 80% AMI; announced revision retained eight homes. ³
Other objectives	Grocery, retail, plaza, mobility/safety, construction-period grocery access. ⁵	Primarily small-scale affordable-home delivery and site/layout questions. ³⁴
Professional inputs	Developer, architect, zoning counsel, grocery operator, community organization, Planning/ZBA, transportation considerations, financing/geotechnical inputs. The record itself shows multiple program and zoning dependencies. ¹¹	Nonprofit developer, neighborhood partner, architect/engineer, zoning counsel/reviewer; materially narrower decision surface. ³
Regulatory change that is easy to explain	Not enough detail on the 2021 proposal to isolate every changed check.	The attached-dwelling conflict identified in Proposal A is removed by an all-detached B; other reviews cannot be assumed away without the revised plan. ³
Financial evidence	Only public claims; no credible full feasibility dataset recovered. ⁸	A specific \$120,000/time-delay estimate exists but remains a developer claim rather than independently tested feasibility. ³⁵
Evidence burden	High; fragmented across years, parties and a large mixed-use proposal.	Low-to-moderate; A and announced B can be described in a handful of fields.
Prototype suitability	Useful second-stage stress test.	Better weekend demo.

The important caveat is that the case-specific City ZBA decision PDF linked from the public record could not be successfully fetched in this research environment. Therefore I cannot responsibly state the exact code sections for every Lanark variance/special exception or assert that the revised all-detached design became entirely by-right. WESA establishes the broad legal change; the primary decision and revised zoning file remain inputs that should be acquired before a production tool automates the rule mapping. ³

Recommendation: use Lanark as the demonstration brief, then use Shur Save as the stress test.

Lanark asks a meaningful but bounded question: *does changing six attached homes to detached homes solve the identified zoning problem, what stays the same, what new costs/delays are claimed, and what still needs checking before proceeding?* That is small enough for two people to structure manually over a weekend without pretending to build a complete Pittsburgh zoning engine. Shur Save then tests whether the same brief format survives mixed uses, historical proposal versions, overlapping standards, community commitments and missing financial inputs. ³⁶

This case also exposes exactly the failure mode the product should avoid: **“Proposal B needs less controversial relief, therefore B is better.”** The publicly stated housing output remains eight homes, while the developer says the redesign creates additional cost and delay. The brief should put those facts side by side without adjudicating whether the legal, design, financial or community tradeoff is worth it. ³⁵

Brief field specification

The design principle should be **comparison without false optimization**. There should be no aggregate “zoning score,” “housing score,” or green checkmark declaring a winner simply because one proposal has fewer discretionary reviews. Shur Save is the caution: a project requiring substantial relief nevertheless contained 248 homes, inclusionary units, grocery access, retail, a plaza and negotiated community commitments. Lanark is the counterexample in miniature: a design change may simplify one identified zoning conflict while preserving unit count but introducing claimed time and cost consequences. ³⁷

Brief field	Decision it supports	Where the value comes from	Available at early screening?	What to show when unknown
Decision frame / applicant objective	Defines what must be preserved while options change: e.g., “deliver eight affordable homes,” or “housing + full-service grocery.”	Prevents approval simplicity from silently replacing the applicant's actual objective. Shur Save's community process explicitly carried both housing and grocery objectives. ²⁸	Usually yes , if applicant states it.	Objective not confirmed – obtain applicant/project brief.

Brief field	Decision it supports	Where the value comes from	Available at early screening?	What to show when unknown
Proposal status, version and date	Determines whether A and B are genuine alternatives, sequential revisions, or a historical/hypothetical comparison.	Shur Save's 2021 concept is documented but not shown to be a live 2023 choice; Lanark B was an announced post-ruling revision. ⁴	Yes.	Status unknown; never default to "alternative."
Physical program for A and B	Lets the team see the actual change: units, tenure/affordability, bedrooms, height/stories, uses, floor area, parking/loading, open space, footprint where known.	These inputs drive both housing outcomes and zoning checks. PublicSource's Shur Save account illustrates how height, retail, parking and housing were interconnected. ¹⁵	Mostly; geometry may mature later.	Individual cells say Not in reviewed source; do not infer dimensions.
Housing and non-housing outcome delta	Answers "what do we gain/lose or preserve?" independently of regulatory burden.	Lanark preserves eight announced homes across A/B; Shur Save carried grocery/plaza/retail objectives alongside housing. ³⁸	Yes at concept level.	Outcome cannot be calculated from current plan.
Effective-date rule baseline	Prevents use of today's rules to judge an older proposal and anchors each check to the correct code/version.	LNC §904.02 and Chapter 916 provisions predate the Shur Save decision, while Bloomfield's IZ overlay took effect in 2022. ³⁹	Usually yes after parcel/zoning lookup.	Historical rule not verified; link current rule separately and explicitly forbid retrospective application.

Brief field	Decision it supports	Where the value comes from	Available at early screening?	What to show when unknown
Checks that change A → B, with causal reason	Identifies exactly what design modification changes a rule or review: attached → detached ⇒ attached-dwelling issue changes ; 4 → 6 stories ⇒ height check changes .	This is the core software value: trace regulatory consequences back to proposal changes rather than producing an opaque pass/fail. 38	Partly.	Potentially affected – dimension/interpretation needed ; no invented outcome.
Constraints that persist	Stops users from thinking one changed check solves the project.	At Shur Save, a height change would not by itself resolve grocery operations, inclusionary obligations, access, compatibility, financing or community objectives; at Lanark, moving to detached homes does not establish what happened to parking or every parcel/setback check. 40	Yes for obvious constraints; refine later.	Persistence not verified – requires revised plan/zoning review.
Required reviews and unresolved interpretations	Tells the practitioner where professional judgment or public approval is still needed.	Shur Save demonstrates the difference between variance questions and a grocery special exception; Lanark shows that several forms of relief can coexist. 41	Yes in broad form.	Review type unresolved ; identify who should decide it rather than guessing.

Brief field	Decision it supports	Where the value comes from	Available at early screening?	What to show when unknown
Community/ public commitments and status	Determines whether a redesign preserves negotiated non-code outcomes.	Echo's voucher position evolved between July reporting and the November record, while BDC also recorded grocery-access and safety commitments. ⁴²	Sometimes.	Discussed, offered, reported commitment, condition of approval, or binding status unknown —never collapse these states.
Financial dependencies and feasibility status	Shows which design decisions require an economic answer before a practitioner can recommend proceeding.	Echo linked height to project costs; City of Bridges linked Lanark redesign to added cost/time. Neither is an independent feasibility study. ⁴³	Dependencies: yes. Full feasibility: often no .	Financial feasibility NOT EVALUATED; then list required inputs such as credible cost, revenue, financing, subsidy/lease and site-condition data.
Evidence, assumptions, conflicts and missing facts	Helps decide whether to act, investigate, or seek professional confirmation.	Shur Save sources differ between “roughly two acres” and “1.7-acre” descriptions, and the complete four-variance record was not recoverable here. ¹¹	Yes; this should start on day one.	Display conflicts side-by-side with source/date. Never silently pick a value.
Next action: action + responsible role + document + reason	Converts comparison into a real project decision.	The previous fields identify the missing input that is blocking the next conclusion.	Yes; becomes more specific over time.	Next action cannot be assigned until [named missing fact] is resolved.

There are two especially important interface rules.

First, every regulatory result should preserve its provenance in a compact form such as **“LNC max height — 45 ft / 3 stories — \$904.02 — rule effective before decision date — source checked [date].”** The eCode

currently records the LNC section's origin in 2003 and the Residential Compatibility chapter's relevant enactment in 2018, while Bloomfield's inclusionary expansion became effective May 2, 2022. ³⁹

Second, use a small controlled vocabulary for certainty: **Verified fact; Applicant/developer claim; Community/stakeholder claim; Professional interpretation needed; Conflicting sources; Missing; Financially unevaluated.** That would have prevented three distortions in this record: turning Echo's "height is necessary" assertion into a demonstrated pro forma conclusion, turning BDC's support into independent evidence of feasibility, and turning Lanark's reported \$120,000 impact into an audited redesign cost. ³⁷

Sample one-page brief and feedback test

Demonstration case: Lanark Street affordable infill, Fineview

Decision moment: after the September 2023 court ruling, before relying on the announced all-detached revision as the project's new zoning strategy. ³⁵

	Proposal A — original	Proposal B — announced revision
Status	Prior proposal; received ZBA approval, subsequently challenged and overturned on the variance issue. ³	Announced post-ruling revision; final revised plan/ approval record not recovered. ³⁵
Applicant objective	Build eight new affordable single-family homes on Lanark Street for households below 80% AMI. ³⁴	Same publicly stated objective: eight new homes. ³⁵
Housing outcome	8 new homes: 6 attached, 2 detached. ³⁴	8 new homes: all 8 detached. ³⁵
Known affordability outcome	Below 80% AMI. ³⁴	No public evidence found that the announced redesign changed the affordability objective. Treat as stated program retained , pending final financing/plan documents. ³⁵
Changed check	ZBA granted two variances plus a special exception; reporting links the relief to attached dwellings and parking requirements. ³⁴	Changing all homes to detached addresses the attached-dwelling issue identified in A. Do not infer that every zoning issue disappears. Revised parking, setbacks and other parcel/site checks were not found. ⁴⁴
Persistent constraints	Parcel/site dimensions, parking arrangement, financing, engineering and the need to deliver eight affordable homes.	Those constraints are not shown to disappear merely because the houses become detached. Exact revised geometry is unknown.

	Proposal A — original	Proposal B — announced revision
Approval history	ZBA approval in March 2023; neighbors appealed; court later ruled the project should not have received the variance. ³	Additional zoning review was anticipated by the developer; final disposition not recovered. ³⁵
Financial consequence	Baseline not publicly quantified in the reviewed sources.	City of Bridges' executive director estimated about \$120,000 additional cost and at least one year of additional time for fundraising, engineering and zoning review. Claim only; financial feasibility not independently evaluated. ³⁵
Key tradeoff	Attached form supported the eight-home program but required relief that became the subject of the successful challenge. ³	Eight-home count is preserved in the announced redesign, but the developer reports added cost/ time; remaining zoning/site constraints are not documented well enough to call B “by-right” or “better.” ³⁵
Most dangerous misleading conclusion	colspan	“All-detached Proposal B solves zoning and is therefore the better housing option.” The evidence only supports that the attached-dwelling issue changes; it does not establish the full approval path, final cost, financing viability or superiority of B. ⁴⁴
Missing documents	Exact ZBA decision/code sections and underlying site plan were not successfully recovered in this research.	Revised all-detached site plan; fresh zoning determination/application; parking layout; parcel-by-parcel setbacks/dimensions; updated financing/ cost basis.
Recommended next action	colspan	Development project manager + zoning counsel/architect: put the announced all-detached site plan against the same parcel-by-parcel zoning checklist used for A and obtain/ confirm the revised zoning determination. Reason: determine exactly which relief disappears and what persists before treating the redesign as a resolved path.

That brief does **not** answer “Which proposal wins?” It answers a narrower, actionable question: **what changed enough to alter the zoning problem, and what must be known next before the team commits to the revised design?** That is the level at which the public Lanark evidence is strongest. ³

The three-question feedback request to Jack should be deliberately concrete rather than asking whether the concept seems useful:

1. **Which statement or missing fact in this Lanark brief could make the comparison misleading?**
2. **Who would actually use a brief like this on a Pittsburgh project, and at what point would they use it?**
3. **After reading it, what would that person do differently—what decision, document request, design revision, or conversation would change?**

The best next delivery-side reviewer after that is an **affordable-housing development/project manager**, ideally someone who has had to coordinate design, zoning, financing and construction on a real Pittsburgh infill project. City of Bridges Community Land Trust is particularly relevant because it was one of the Lanark developers and continues to describe itself as a developer of permanently affordable housing. Its official current public contact route is its [contact form](#); the organization's site also publicly lists Fineview/Lanark properties. No contact was made. ⁴⁵

The feedback standard should be demanding: another general endorsement is weak evidence. A useful response identifies **one false implication, one missing input that changes the conclusion, or one concrete next action that the brief makes easier**. That would test the design's decision value rather than product enthusiasm.

Unresolved datapoints and evidence limits

These are ranked by how much they could change the brief design, not by how interesting they are historically.

Rank	Unresolved datapoint	Why it could change the design
1 — Highest impact	The complete Shur Save 2023 application/ZBA decision: all four requested variances, exact code sections, plans submitted, evidence/findings and disposition of each request. PublicSource confirms four variance requests, while accessible decision reporting identifies only height and Residential Compatibility issues plus the approved grocery special exception. ⁹	This determines whether the product can produce a reliable machine-readable “checks changed / checks persist” matrix from public records or needs mandatory practitioner confirmation before displaying it.
2	The full 2021 Echo Shur Save concept: site plan, uses, grocery/retail program, 190-unit mix, parking, affordability assumptions, height in feet and contemplated approvals. Only four stories/190 apartments were recovered. ¹⁵	Without it, Shur Save's only same-developer A/B comparison risks false symmetry. Finding it could turn Shur Save from a retrospective version diff into a strong genuine comparison example.

Rank	Unresolved datapoint	Why it could change the design
3	The final/revised Lanark all-detached site plan and zoning disposition. WESA establishes the announced eight-detached-home revision but not its complete zoning checklist. ³⁵	This is the most important missing item for the prototype. It determines whether the tool correctly says “one conflict changes” or can say precisely which approvals disappear, persist, or are newly triggered.
4	The case-specific Lanark ZBA decision and court order, including the exact code provisions and judicial reasoning. WESA reports two variances plus a special exception and the later reversal, but the underlying decision PDF was not successfully retrievable here. ³	This tests whether the product must distinguish “rule triggered,” “relief requested,” “relief approved,” and “approval legally sustained.” Those are materially different states.
5	Credible Shur Save financial inputs sufficient to test the claimed relationship between height, affordability, grocery/site costs and feasibility. The public evidence recovered contains only party/ stakeholder statements, including Echo's cost claim and the later topography/soil argument. ⁸	This determines whether the brief should remain purely a zoning/ program comparison or can ever add a bounded financial-sensitivity module. Until such inputs exist, the correct output is Financial feasibility: not evaluated.

A further evidence-quality issue worth retaining in the data model is **commitment status**. Shur Save's voucher language moved from a July statement that Echo would encourage a future operator to participate to later reporting that Echo had agreed to voucher acceptance. A useful brief needs source date, speaker, status, and ideally documentary evidence of whether a commitment was voluntary, contractual, or a formal approval condition. ⁷

The ACTION-Housing YouTube presentation supplied as a starting source could not be reliably fetched or transcribed in this research environment, so I have not manufactured timestamps or used it as support for any substantive conclusion. Likewise, several original City PDFs could not be rendered; where this prevented primary verification, that limitation is stated rather than filled from inference.

Source register

The register distinguishes material actually extracted from material located but not successfully rendered. For HTML pages, page numbers and timestamps are not applicable. For inaccessible PDFs/video, no page or timestamp is invented.

Source	Date	Relevant page / section / timestamp	Use and access status
Pittsburgh Code, Chapter 904 — Mixed Use Zoning Districts	Current page; §904.02 records Ord. 45-2003 effective Dec. 31, 2003	§904.02 LNC; HTML	Primary rule source for LNC purpose, Residential Compatibility cross-reference and 45-foot/three-story base height. Because it is the current compilation rather than an archived 2023 snapshot, used only with its enactment history and contemporary corroboration. ⁴⁶
Pittsburgh Code, Chapter 916 — Residential Compatibility Standards	Relevant general provision records Ord. 31-2018 effective Aug. 6, 2018	§§916.01–916.09; HTML	Primary source for applicability, height/setback framework and waiver standards. ⁴⁷
City of Pittsburgh Legistar, File 2021-1707	Passed Apr. 19, 2022; effective May 2, 2022	Legislative text; HTML	Primary source for expansion of Inclusionary Housing Overlay into Bloomfield and associated standards. ¹⁴
Shur Save ZBA decision, 4401 Liberty Avenue, case 112 of 2023	Nov. 6, 2023	Pages unavailable: fetch timed out	Located through WESA/BDC. Original decision is the most important missing primary record; detailed findings were therefore taken only from contemporaneous reporting, not from unrendered pages.
ZBA agenda for Aug. 10, 2023	Aug. 10, 2023	Search index identifies 4401 Liberty; relevant page not successfully rendered	Primary agenda located; no unverified section numbers extracted.
City Development Activities Meeting report — 4401 Liberty	July 11, 2023	Page unavailable due access block	Primary meeting document located. Search indexing corroborated the 248-unit/unit-mix material, but page-specific extraction was not possible.

Source	Date	Relevant page / section / timestamp	Use and access status
Bloomfield Central Gateway Development Guidelines PDF	Developed through 2019 workshops; PDF posted by early 2020	Pages unavailable due fetch failure	Original community-planning document located. Community objectives used in this report are instead supported by BDC/ PublicSource's accessible descriptions of the process. 22
BDC advocacy history — Shur Save	Current historical page	HTML	Primary stakeholder account of January 2018 meeting, 2019 workshops, early-2020 Echo acquisition and petition. 48
PublicSource / NEXTpittsburgh — “New Giant Eagle and apartment complex could cause zoning changes in Bloomfield”	July 26, 2023	HTML	Best pre-hearing source for 2023 program, parking, four reported variances, 2019 guidelines and 2021 four-story/190-unit Echo concept. 15
WESA — “Development plans for the former Bloomfield ShurSave hit a snag”	Nov. 7, 2023	HTML	Decision reporting: height/RCS denials, grocery special exception, project program, financial claim and community commitments. 49
BDC — “ZBA Decision Regarding Echo Realty Proposal for Bloomfield ShurSave Site”	Nov. 6, 2023	HTML	Stakeholder account of objectives, commitments, support rationale and uncertainty about alternatives. Not treated as independent feasibility analysis. 50
WESA — “Developer of Bloomfield ShurSave appeals zoning board rejection”	Dec. 6, 2023; updated Dec. 7	HTML	Appeal arguments concerning topography, soils, dimensional relief and ZBA rationale. 12
BDC — intervention in 4401 Liberty appeal	Jan. 30, 2024	HTML	Later record of housing/grocery priorities and community-planning history. 28
BDC — Giant Eagle acquisition / lost housing proposal	July 11, 2024	HTML	Later outcome separating the eventual property transfer/no-housing result from facts available at the November 2023 decision. 29

Source	Date	Relevant page / section / timestamp	Use and access status
WESA — “Fineview zoning dispute over affordable development lands in court”	Apr. 25, 2023	HTML	Lanark Proposal A: eight homes, six attached/two detached, affordability and reported ZBA relief. ³⁴
WESA — “Judge's ruling means North Side affordable housing project must go back to the drawing board”	Sept. 22, 2023	HTML	Lanark court outcome, announced all-detached Proposal B and developer's \$120,000/one-year estimate. ³⁵
Pro-Housing Pittsburgh — “You Can't Build That Here — 21 Lanark St”	Page displays “Nov 22”; retrieved page does not expose the year in its visible date field	HTML	Starting-source/advocacy description of existing rowhouse and zoning context. Consequential project facts were cross-checked against WESA rather than accepted solely from this source. ³³
City of Bridges CLT contact	Current as retrieved Sept. 26, 2026	HTML	Official public route for a delivery-side follow-up reviewer; current site also lists Fineview/Lanark properties. No contact made. ⁵¹
ACTION-Housing presentation supplied in the research prompt	Date/timestamps not reliably retrievable here	Transcript/timestamps unavailable	Fetch/transcript could not be reliably accessed. No substantive factual claim in this report depends on it.

The research therefore points to a deliberately modest first product: **a brief that makes proposal changes, regulatory consequences, preserved objectives, evidentiary status, missing inputs, and the next professional action unmistakable.** The Shur Save record suggests that trying to answer zoning, community tradeoffs and financial feasibility all at once would exceed what the evidence can support. Lanark suggests that doing the narrower comparison well—especially showing *what changed, what did not, and what still cannot be concluded*—is both testable and potentially useful. ⁵²

¹ ⁴ ⁷ ⁹ ¹¹ ¹⁵ ²⁵ ³¹ ⁴⁰ ⁴² ⁵² <https://www.publicsource.org/giant-eagle-apartment-complex-echo-realty-zoning-bloomfield-pittsburgh/>

<https://www.publicsource.org/giant-eagle-apartment-complex-echo-realty-zoning-bloomfield-pittsburgh/>

² ¹⁰ ¹⁶ ³² ³⁹ ⁴⁶ <https://ecode360.com/45474257>

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